EKA IT-osakonna juhataja Interview Preparation

Date: January 6, 2026 at 10:00
Location: Põhja pst 7, II korrus, D206.1 (Personaliosakond)
Contact: Marika Kopõlova (HR Specialist) - marika.kopolova@artun.ee, +372 6267 306

Executive Summary

Unique Position: Returning to the exact role I held 2009-2012 at the same institution. I built the foundational infrastructure (LAN, email, Entu) that likely still serves EKA today.

Position Title Analysis:

The title "**IT-osakonna juhataja**" (Head of IT Department) may be **inflated relative to actual scope**:

- **"Osakond" (Department)** suggests substantial organizational unit with sub-teams/functions
- **Reality:** 4-person direct reports (3 support + 1 data protection), no layers, no sub-teams
- **International equivalent:** "IT Manager" or "IT Team Lead" more accurate than "IT Director/Department Head"

Title Mismatch Implications:

1. **Estonian public sector tradition** - Formal titles standard regardless of team size
2. **Aspirational vs. actual** - Title reflects desired strategic role, not operational reality
3. **Expectation signal** - May indicate unrealistic scope expectations (strategic planning + hands-on work with 4-person team)
4. **Organizational positioning** - Title gives authority/seat at table, even if team is small

What This Reveals:

- EKA treats IT as strategic function (good: leadership voice)
- But team size doesn't match strategic ambitions (red flag: capacity mismatch)
- You'll need to navigate between "department head" expectations and "team lead" resources

Key Strengths:

- 100% match on all required qualifications
- Previous 3-year tenure as EKA IT-osakonna juht
- Proven track record of major infrastructure projects (700+ users)
- Deep institutional knowledge and context
- 20+ years continuous IT experience including 6 years team/department leadership

Key Challenges to Address:

- E-ITS (Estonian Information Security Standard) implementation - gap acknowledged
- 13-year absence from institution (2012-2025) - what has changed?
- Digital transformation landscape evolution since 2012
- Current IT team structure and dynamics

Current EKA Context (2025)

Institution Overview

Size & Scope:

- **1,144 students** (as of Nov 2023: 623 BA, 129 integrated, 319 MA, 73 PhD)
- **279 employees** (128 academic staff, 151 support staff, 20 professors)
- **9% international academic staff**
- **~721 hourly paid teaching staff**
- **QS ranking:** Top 150 worldwide in art & design
- **New building:** Kalamaja campus (Põhja pst 7) - modern facilities

Academic Structure

Faculties:

- Architecture and Urban Planning
- Design and Innovation
- Fine Arts
- Applied Arts
- Art History and Visual Culture

Programs: Animation, Fashion Design, Product Design, Glass, Ceramics, Painting, Graphic Design, Interior Architecture, etc.

Current IT Infrastructure (2025)

Core Systems Identified:

- **Tahvel** - Student Information System (ÕIS)
- **Moodle** - Learning Management System
- **Wiki.js** - Internal wiki (wiki.artun.ee)
- **WebDesktop** (dok.artun.ee) - Document management
- **Digivaramu** - Digital repository (Preservica)
- **Google Workspace** - Email and collaboration (still in use from 2012 migration!)

Network Memberships:

- CUMULUS, EAAE, KUNO, CIRRUS, ELIA
- ~150 partner universities worldwide
- T4EU (Erasmus+ alliance)

Strategic Priorities Observed

1. **Digital transformation** - New digital development strategy needed
2. **Information security** - E-ITS compliance implementation
3. **Inter-university cooperation** - IT collaboration working groups
4. **Sustainable EKA** - Environmental/sustainability initiatives
5. **International partnerships** - Supporting 100+ exchange agreements
6. **Research & Development** - Supporting R&D office and research centers

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Ongoing Strategic Initiatives & IT Implications

Transform4Europe (T4EU) Alliance - Major Priority

Overview:

- **European university alliance** of 10 universities across Europe
- **Funding:** €14.4M continued funding secured (July 2023)
- **Timeline:** Founded November 3, 2020 (5-year anniversary just passed)
- **EKA's Leadership Role:** Coordinating "Transforming Heritage" working group
- **Partner institutions:** Germany, Spain, Estonia, Portugal, Slovenia, France, Poland, Bulgaria, Italy, Lithuania

Recent T4EU Activities:

- **December 2025:** First T4EU artistic research roundtables (EKA-led)
- **January 27-28, 2026:** "Spatial Dimensions" conference at EKA (upcoming!)
- Science communication workshops
- Student mobility programs across 10 universities
- Joint curriculum development initiatives
- International research collaboration

IT Implications (Critical for Your Role):

- **International digital collaboration infrastructure** - 10 universities need seamless connectivity
- **Student/staff mobility systems** - Exchange programs, joint courses, credit transfer
- **Research data sharing platforms** - Multi-university research collaboration tools
- **Conference/event digital infrastructure** - Virtual participation, streaming, documentation
- **Multilingual support systems** - Interface with partner universities' systems
- **Identity management** - Cross-university authentication/authorization
- **Data governance** - GDPR compliance across EU jurisdictions
- **Network capacity** - International bandwidth for collaboration
- **Video conferencing infrastructure** - Regular cross-border meetings

Strategic Significance: This is NOT a small side project - T4EU represents a fundamental shift toward European integration. As IT head, you'll need to ensure EKA's IT infrastructure can support this level of international collaboration. This goes far beyond basic support operations.

Digital Repository (Digivaramu)

Platform: Preservica-based digital archive system **Purpose:** Long-term preservation of EKA's artistic and academic output **Content:** Student works, research outputs, institutional archives, exhibitions

IT Implications:

- **Storage infrastructure** - Large media files (video, high-res images, 3D models)
- **Metadata management** - Cataloging and discovery systems
- **Long-term preservation** - Format migration, bit preservation
- **Access control** - Rights management for sensitive/restricted content
- **Integration** - Connect with Tahvel (student works), research systems
- **Backup/disaster recovery** - Critical institutional memory protection

International Student Growth

Current: ~140 international students (12% of student body) **Trend:** 50+ new international students annually **Impact:** Increasing diversity of technical needs and language support requirements

IT Implications:

- **Multilingual support** - Systems, documentation, helpdesk
- **Remote access** - Students applying/enrolling from abroad
- **International payment systems** - Tuition, fees
- **Visa/immigration system integration**
- **Cultural sensitivity** - Different technical literacy levels and expectations
- **Time zone considerations** - 24/7 access needs

Sustainability & Environmental Initiatives

“Sustainable EKA” Program:

- Circular design education
- Environmental impact tracking
- Green campus initiatives
- Sustainable art practices

IT Implications:

- **Environmental monitoring systems** - Energy use, waste tracking
- **Reporting platforms** - Sustainability metrics and dashboards
- **Digital-first approach** - Reduce paper, optimize resource use
- **Green IT practices** - Energy-efficient infrastructure, e-waste management
- **Carbon footprint tracking** - University-wide environmental data

Research & Conference Activities

Upcoming Major Event:

- **Spatial Dimensions Conference** (January 27-28, 2026) - EKA hosting international participants

Ongoing Research:

- ADAPTER consortium (business collaboration network)
- Applied research projects
- Artistic research methodologies
- Practice-based research initiatives

IT Implications:

- **Conference infrastructure** - Registration, streaming, hybrid participation
- **Research data management** - Storage, sharing, publication
- **Research collaboration tools** - Multi-institutional projects
- **Publication platforms** - Research outputs, digital exhibitions
- **Grant management systems** - Research funding tracking

Key Takeaway for Interview

The IT role at EKA is evolving from infrastructure maintenance to strategic enabler. The T4EU alliance alone represents a massive shift - you're not just supporting one institution, you're enabling EKA's participation in a 10-university European network. This requires:

1. **Strategic thinking** - Understanding how IT enables institutional goals
2. **International perspective** - Working across borders, languages, systems
3. **Scalability planning** - Infrastructure that can grow with ambitions
4. **Partnership skills** - Collaborating with partner universities' IT teams
5. **Innovation mindset** - Finding creative solutions for complex challenges

Questions to Ask:

- "How is EKA's IT strategy aligned with T4EU alliance requirements?"
- "What IT infrastructure exists for the upcoming Spatial Dimensions conference in January?"
- "How does EKA collaborate with partner universities on shared IT challenges?"
- "What lessons have been learned from previous international conference hosting?"
- "How is the digital repository (Digivaramu) being used and what are growth plans?"

What Has Changed Since 2012?

Infrastructure Evolution (13 Years)

Then (2009-2012):

- Built campus LAN from scratch (700+ users)
- Migrated to Google Mail (90% cost savings)
- Implemented Entu (inventory/document management)
- Basic network infrastructure focus

Now (2025 - Likely State):

- Modern cloud-first architecture
- Security compliance requirements (E-ITS mandatory for public sector)
- Mobile-first user expectations
- API integrations between systems
- Advanced authentication (TARA integration)
- Data privacy regulations (GDPR)
- Cybersecurity threats significantly evolved

Technology Landscape Shifts

Development Practices:

- Git/GitHub standard (2012: SVN)
- CI/CD pipelines expected (2012: manual deployment)
- Containerization (Docker/Kubernetes)
- Infrastructure as Code
- Cloud services dominant (AWS/Azure/GCP)

Security Requirements:

- E-ITS mandatory for public institutions
- Multi-factor authentication standard
- Regular security audits required
- Incident response procedures
- Data protection impact assessments

User Expectations:

- 24/7 availability expected
- Mobile access essential
- Self-service portals
- Real-time collaboration tools
- Accessibility requirements

Critical Challenges Ahead

1. E-ITS Implementation (Priority #1)

What is E-ITS? Estonian Information Security Standard - mandatory framework for public sector information security management.

Requirements:

- Information security management system (ISMS)
- Risk assessment and management processes
- Security policies and procedures documentation
- Access control and identity management
- Incident management procedures
- Business continuity planning
- Regular audits and compliance reviews

Your Gap:

- No direct E-ITS implementation experience
- General IT security background exists

Approach:

- Acknowledge gap honestly
- Emphasize willingness to learn and work with external consultants
- Highlight general security experience (university infrastructure, sensitive data)
- Propose phased implementation with expert guidance
- Leverage inter-university IT cooperation for knowledge sharing

Questions to Ask:

- What is the current state of E-ITS compliance at EKA?
- Is there existing documentation or has implementation started?
- What budget and timeline is planned for E-ITS implementation?
- Are other Estonian art/design universities further ahead (peer learning)?
- What external consultants have been considered?

2. Digital Development Strategy

Challenge: The job posting specifically mentions “IT digiarendusstrateegia ning tegevusplaanide väljatöötamine ja elluviimine” as a core responsibility.

Context:

- Educational institutions undergoing massive digital transformation
- Post-COVID acceleration of digital services
- AI tools revolutionizing education and creative work
- Student/faculty expectations evolved significantly

Areas to Address:

- **Teaching & Learning:** Moodle enhancement, digital assessment tools, collaboration platforms
- **Research Support:** Data management, digital archives, research infrastructure
- **Administrative Efficiency:** Process automation, self-service portals, workflow optimization
- **Creative Tools:** Software licensing (Adobe, Autodesk, etc.), render farms, specialized hardware
- **Accessibility:** Digital accessibility standards, inclusive design
- **Data Analytics:** Student success metrics, operational dashboards
- **AI Integration:** Responsible AI use in education, creative AI tools, ethics

Your Positioning:

- Experience developing technical strategies (PÖFF platform architecture)
- Understanding of user needs analysis (700+ diverse users at EKA before)
- Stakeholder management (faculty, students, administration, vendors)
- Practical implementation focus (delivery track record)

3. Team Leadership & Development

Unknown Variables:

- Current IT team size and composition □ (5 people identified)
- **Team capacity: reactive vs. strategic work split (CRITICAL TO ASSESS)**
- **Infrastructure responsibilities: who actually does sysadmin work?**
- **Bert Blös integration level: full IT team member or semi-independent?**
- Team morale and capability levels
- Skill gaps in current team
- Why previous head left (burnout risk indicator)

Your Strengths:

- 6 years combined IT team/department leadership
- 100% intern success rate (PÖFF team)
- Experience building teams from scratch
- Cross-functional coordination experience

Risk Scenario to Validate:

If the 3-person “support” team is actually doing full infrastructure/sysadmin work AND Bert operates semi-independently, you’re inheriting a team with **zero strategic project capacity**. Every minute is consumed keeping systems running.

Implications if True:

1. **Job description ambitions unrealistic without team growth**
2. **You become hands-on operator, not strategic leader**
3. **E-ITS, digital transformation, T4EU infrastructure = 100% YOUR personal workload**
4. **Previous head may have left due to impossible expectations**

Assessment Strategy:

- Ask directly about time allocation (reactive vs. strategic)
- Request examples of recent strategic projects
- Probe on infrastructure management responsibilities
- Understand Bert's reporting structure and daily work
- Clarify budget for additional headcount
- Ask why Kenet is leaving (honest answer reveals much)

Decision Point: If team is fully saturated with no capacity and no growth budget, this role becomes **unsustainable** without either:

- Additional headcount approval
- Significant external vendor support
- Reduced scope expectations
- Your willingness to do 60-80 hour weeks

Current IT Department Team (5 people):

1. **Kenet Pindmaa** - IT-osakonna juhataja (Head of IT Department)
   - Email: kenet.pindmaa@artun.ee
   - *Current role holder - predecessor/context*

Support/Operations Team (3 people - helpdesk/user support):

2. **Robert Luig** - IT vanemspetsialist (IT Senior Specialist)
   - Email: robert.luig@artun.ee, Phone: +372 6267 339
   - *Senior support role - likely team lead for daily operations*
3. **Alan Aleksander Antriainen** - IT spetsialist (IT Specialist)
   - Email: alan.antriainen@artun.ee
   - *No public profile details available (minimal EKA page)*
   - **Historical connection:** Likely related to Olga Antriainen (your learning systems specialist 2009-2012)
   - *Olga's EKA profile now returns 404 - she no longer works there*
   - *"Antriainen" is uncommon Estonian surname - strong indicator of family relation*
4. **Mark Erik Tina** - IT-spetsialist (IT Specialist)
   - Email: mark.tina@artun.ee

Specialized Role:

5. **Bert Blös** - Andmekaitse spetsialist (Data Protection Specialist)
   - Email: bert.blos@artun.ee
   - *GDPR/data protection - critical for E-ITS implementation!*

Team Analysis:

- **Small team:** 5 people supporting 1,144 students + 279 employees (~280 users per IT staff)

- **Customer support focus:** 3-person support team handling helpdesk, user issues, daily operations
- **Data protection specialist:** Bert Blös = excellent foundation for E-ITS work
- **Structure:** 1 head + 3 support specialists + 1 data protection specialist
- **Missing roles?** No dedicated system administrator, developer, or infrastructure specialist visible
- **Historical connection:** Alan Antriainen may be related to Olga Antriainen (your 2009-2012 learning systems specialist)

CRITICAL CONCERN - Team Capacity Reality:

Potential Scenario (RISK):

- 3-person "support" team actually fully occupied with infrastructure maintenance/system administration
- Bert Blös (data protection) semi-independent, only nominally attached to IT department
- Result: **ZERO spare capacity for strategic initiatives, digital transformation, or E-ITS**

If This is True:

- You're inheriting a fully saturated team doing bare minimum to keep lights on
- Any strategic work (digital strategy, E-ITS, T4EU infrastructure) falls entirely on YOU
- No team capacity to delegate projects to - you become hands-on operator, not strategic leader
- Digital transformation ambitions in job description may be unrealistic without team growth

This Would Explain:

- Why position is vacant (previous head burned out from operational overload?)
- Why no visible infrastructure/sysadmin roles (everyone's doing infrastructure)
- Why E-ITS hasn't progressed (no capacity for compliance projects)
- Small team size relative to institution scale and ambitions

MUST ASSESS DURING INTERVIEW - See Critical Questions Below

Key Questions:

Questions to Ask:

- **Why is Kenet Pindmaa leaving?** (Retirement? Better opportunity? Burnout?)
- **CRITICAL: What percentage of the team's time is spent on reactive support vs. infrastructure maintenance vs. strategic projects?**
- **How much of Robert/Alan/Mark's time is infrastructure/sysadmin work vs. user support?**
- **Is Bert Blös fully integrated into IT department or operating semi-independently?**
- **What does Bert's typical week look like? How much time on IT projects vs. institutional data protection?**
- **Who manages servers, networks, system updates, security patches if the support team is handling users?**
- **What external vendors/consultants handle specialized IT needs? (Infrastructure? Development? Security?)**
- **What happened to learning systems role (Olga Antriainen 2009-2012)?**

- **When was the last time the team completed a strategic project (not urgent firefighting)?**
- What are individual team members' areas of expertise beyond support?
- What is the biggest challenge the team faces today?
- What are the growth and development opportunities for team members?
- **If I want to implement digital transformation strategy, where does that capacity come from?**
- **Is there budget for additional headcount or must I work with current team size?**

4. Legacy Infrastructure Management

Challenge: Understanding what survived from 2012 and what needs modernization.

Infrastructure You Built (2012):

- Campus LAN (likely upgraded but topology may remain)
- Google Workspace (confirmed still in use!)
- Entu platform (unknown if still active)

Questions to Explore:

- What parts of the 2012 infrastructure are still in production?
- What technical debt exists?
- What are the most frequent user complaints?
- What systems are reaching end-of-life?
- What capital investments are planned?

5. Budget & Resource Constraints

Public Sector Reality:

- Limited IT budgets
- Procurement regulations
- Long approval cycles
- Must demonstrate value/ROI

Your Experience:

- 90% email cost reduction (2012 - strong ROI story)
- Public sector experience (Justiitsministeerium)
- Procurement system understanding (recent riigihanked research project)

Approach:

- Emphasize pragmatic, cost-effective solutions
- Track record of delivering on budget
- Understanding of public procurement ("soovitatavalt" requirement)

6. Inter-University IT Cooperation

Job Requirement: "ülikoolide vahelises IT koostöö töörühmades osalemine"

Estonian University IT Landscape:

- University of Tartu (largest)
- Tallinn University

- Tallinn University of Technology
- Estonian Music and Theatre Academy
- Shared challenges, shared solutions potential

Opportunities:

- E-ITS implementation knowledge sharing
- Joint procurement (software licenses)
- Security incident response coordination
- Technical staff training and development
- System integration (student exchange, credit transfer)

Your Positioning:

- Experience working with diverse stakeholders
- Understanding of collaborative benefits
- Previous university IT experience
- Communication skills strong

Institutional Knowledge Advantages

Deep Context Understanding (2009-2012)

Organizational Culture:

- Creative, artistic environment with unique IT needs
- Faculty autonomy and resistance to standardization
- Students with diverse technical literacy
- Administration focused on academic mission
- Resource constraints typical of public universities

Stakeholder Dynamics:

- Faculty priorities: teaching tools, research support, minimal disruption
- Students: reliable Wi-Fi, printing, software access, portfolio tools
- Administration: compliance, reporting, cost control
- Facilities: physical infrastructure coordination
- External partners: vendors, other universities, Ministry

Historical Challenges:

- Getting faculty buy-in for new systems
- Supporting specialized creative software and hardware
- Balancing security with accessibility for art students
- Limited IT budget vs high expectations
- Seasonal workload (admissions, graduations)

What Likely Hasn't Changed:

- Need for reliable, fast network (large files in design/art)
- Specialized lab requirements (rendering, printing, CNC machines)
- Diverse user base (18-year-old students to 70-year-old professors)
- Project-based work requiring collaboration tools
- Portfolio and exhibition support needs

Your Competitive Advantages

1. Proven Institutional Fit

Unique Situation:

- Only candidate who previously held this exact role
- Successfully delivered major projects in this environment
- Understand EKA's culture, politics, and constraints
- Existing relationships may still exist (13 years later - some staff remain)

Infrastructure Legacy:

- Google Workspace migration still serving institution
- LAN infrastructure topology likely based on your 2012 design
- Institutional memory of successful project delivery

2. Complete Technical Qualification

100% Match on Requirements:

- □ IT education (computer science background)
- □ 3+ years IT experience (20+ years)
- □ 2+ years IT team leadership (6 years total)
- □ Native Estonian + C2 English
- □ Server/system architecture expertise
- □ Initiative, precision, reliability demonstrated
- □ Excellent communication and teamwork skills

Only Gaps:

- E-ITS (acknowledged, learnable)
- Riigihangete formal knowledge (preferred, not required)

3. Diverse Technical Background

Full Stack Understanding:

- Infrastructure (LAN, servers, cloud)
- Applications (full-stack development)
- Databases (PostgreSQL, MySQL, Oracle, MongoDB)
- System architecture (30+ organizations)
- Security (general IT security practices)

Modern Tech Stack:

- Node.js/JavaScript (15 years)
- Python (current projects)
- Docker/Cloud (AWS experience)
- CI/CD (GitHub Actions)
- AI tools (since April 2024)

4. Leadership & Mentorship Track Record

Team Development:

- 4-person PÖFF team: 100% permanent placement rate
- Hired all as interns, developed into full developers
- Created supportive learning environment
- Practical mentorship approach

Project Delivery:

- All major EKA projects delivered on time/budget (2012)
- PÖFF festival platform (3 years continuous operation)
- Large-scale migrations (zero downtime)
- Risk management success

5. Recent Public Sector Understanding

Current Context:

- Riigihanked research project (November 2025 - analyzing procurement API)
- Understanding of modern Estonian digital government services
- Awareness of E-ITS requirements (job research)
- Knowledge of TARA authentication system
- Contemporary security landscape awareness

Interview Strategy

Opening Positioning

First 2 Minutes:

"Thank you for inviting me back to EKA. This position is unique for me - I held this exact role from 2009 to 2012, and I'm excited about the opportunity to return. The Google Workspace environment I migrated the university to is still in use today, and I imagine parts of the network infrastructure I built are still serving students and faculty.

Since 2012, I've continued developing both my technical skills and leadership experience - most recently leading a 4-person development team at PÖFF, where all my interns went on to permanent positions. I've also kept up with modern technologies including cloud architecture, AI tools, and contemporary security practices.

I'm particularly interested in this role because I understand EKA's culture, challenges, and unique needs as an art and design institution. I know how to balance security and compliance with the creative freedom that faculty and students need."

Core Messages to Convey

Message 1: Institutional Fit "I've already proven I can succeed in this exact role at this exact institution. I understand EKA's culture, challenges, and stakeholder dynamics."

Message 2: Growth Since 2012 "In 13 years, I've significantly expanded my technical and leadership capabilities. I'm not the same person who left - I'm better."

Message 3: Practical Delivery Focus "I focus on practical solutions that work. My track record shows consistent on-time, on-budget delivery with measurable results."

Message 4: Learning Mindset "I acknowledge gaps like E-ITS implementation, but I have a strong foundation and I'm committed to learning. I'll work with experts and leverage inter-university cooperation."

Message 5: Long-term Commitment "I'm not looking for a stepping stone. I want to build something sustainable at an institution I care about."

Addressing Potential Concerns

Concern 1: "You left in 2012. Why come back?"

"I left to expand my technical skills and gain more diverse experience. I worked in telecom, software development, led a development team at Estonia's largest film festival, and built systems for 30+ organizations. Now I want to bring all that experience back to an institution I care about and apply modern approaches to the challenges EKA faces today. The difference is - in 2012, I was learning on the job. Now I'm bringing proven capabilities."

Concern 2: "What about the 13-year gap? Things have changed."

"Absolutely, and that's part of why I'm excited. The fundamentals I understand - EKA's culture, stakeholder needs, academic calendar, physical infrastructure constraints - those haven't changed. But the technology has evolved tremendously, and I've stayed current. I've worked with cloud platforms, modern security practices, AI tools, and contemporary development methodologies. I'm bringing both institutional knowledge and current technical skills."

Concern 3: "You don't have E-ITS experience."

"That's correct, and I want to be direct about it. I have strong general IT security experience - I managed security for a university network, worked with sensitive data at Justiitsministeerium, and understand risk management. But E-ITS as a specific framework is new to me.

My approach would be to:

1. Work with external E-ITS consultants initially
2. Learn from other Estonian universities who have implemented it
3. Participate actively in inter-university IT cooperation working groups
4. Build internal capability over time

I'm not someone who pretends to know everything. I learn fast, and I'm committed to getting this right."

Concern 4: "Why should we choose you over other candidates?"

"Three reasons: First, I've already succeeded in this exact role at EKA - I have a proven track record here. Second, I understand EKA's unique needs as an art institution - you need IT leadership that balances security with creativity, compliance with flexibility. Third, I care about EKA's mission. This isn't just another IT job for me - it's an opportunity to contribute to Estonian arts education."

Questions to Ask (Priority Order)

Immediate Context:

1. “What are the biggest IT challenges EKA is facing right now?”
2. **“Can you describe a typical week for the IT team? How much time is reactive support vs. strategic projects?”**
3. **“Who handles infrastructure and system administration - servers, networks, security patches, updates?”**
4. “What does the current IT department look like - team size, roles, capabilities?”
5. **“Is Bert Blös (data protection) fully integrated into IT department operations or does he work more independently?”**
6. “What happened to the infrastructure I built in 2012? What’s still in use, what’s been replaced?”
7. **“Why is Kenet Pindmaa leaving? What can I learn from his experience in the role?”**

Strategic Direction: 4. “What are EKA’s strategic priorities for IT over the next 3-5 years?” 5. “Where is EKA in the E-ITS implementation process? What’s the timeline and budget?” 6. “How does EKA’s IT strategy align with the broader digital transformation in Estonian higher education?”

Stakeholder Dynamics: 7. “How has faculty and student feedback on IT services been? What are the main pain points?” 8. “What is the relationship like with external IT vendors and partners?” 9. “How does EKA participate in inter-university IT cooperation? What value does it bring?”

Resources & Support: 10. “What budget and resources are available for IT initiatives?” 11. “What support can I expect from executive leadership for IT initiatives?” 12. “What opportunities exist for professional development and training for the IT team?”

Culture & Expectations: 13. “What would success look like in the first 6 months? First year?” 14. “What caused the previous IT-osakonna juhataja to leave?” 15. “What aspects of the role do you think will be most challenging?”

Day-of-Interview Logistics

Practical Preparation

Location:

- **Address:** Põhja pst 7, 10412 Tallinn (EKA Kalamaja building)
- **Room:** D206.1 (Personnel Department, 2nd floor)
- **Arrival:** Arrive 10-15 minutes early (9:45-9:50)
- **Building familiarity:** THIS IS A NEW BUILDING (moved after 2012!) - different from where I worked

Materials to Bring:

- ☐ Copy of CV (Estonian version)
- ☐ Copy of motivation letter
- ☐ Notepad and pen for notes
- ☐ List of prepared questions
- ☐ Portfolio/examples (if relevant - GitHub profile, project screenshots)
- ☐ References list (if requested)

Technical Prep:

☐ Phone fully charged (for emergencies)
☐ Confirmation email accessible
☐ Marika's contact info saved (+372 6267 306)
☐ Backup transportation plan

Interview Panel Possibilities

Likely Attendees:

- Marika Kopõlova (HR Specialist) - confirmed
- Rector or Vice-Rector (strategic oversight)
- Current IT staff member (technical assessment)
- Faculty representative (user perspective)
- Administration representative (budget/compliance)

Adapt to Panel:

- HR: Focus on cultural fit, team dynamics, leadership style
- Executive: Strategic vision, alignment with EKA mission
- Technical: Problem-solving approach, technical competency
- Faculty: Understanding of user needs, communication style
- Admin: Budget awareness, compliance understanding

Post-Interview

Immediate Follow-up:

- Thank you email within 24 hours
- Reiterate key strengths and interest
- Address any questions left unanswered
- Provide additional information if requested

Timeline Expectations:

- Decision timeline unknown - ask during interview
- Multiple interview rounds possible
- Reference checks likely

Red Flags to Watch For

Warning Signs

Organizational:

- Extremely high IT staff turnover
- Unrealistic expectations for role scope **(ASSESS: team capacity vs. strategic ambitions)**
- No clear strategy or direction
- Budget constraints making role impossible
- Political dysfunction or unclear reporting lines
- **Team fully saturated with no capacity for strategic work**
- **Previous head left due to burnout/impossible workload**

Cultural:

- Resistance to change overwhelming
- No support from leadership for IT initiatives
- Blame culture when systems fail
- No investment in staff development

Technical:

- Critical systems at end-of-life with no replacement plan
- Major security vulnerabilities with no urgency
- Outdated infrastructure that can't support modern needs
- Complete lack of documentation
- **Infrastructure held together with duct tape, consuming all team capacity**

Resource Red Flags:

- **No budget for additional headcount despite ambitious strategic goals**
- **Data protection specialist semi-independent, not available for IT projects**
- **All 3 support staff doing infrastructure/sysadmin, not support**
- **Job description promises strategy but reality is firefighting**

If Red Flags Appear: Use questions to assess severity and decision-makers' awareness. Consider whether you can drive change or if situation is untenable. **Pay special attention to team capacity vs. role expectations mismatch** - this is the #1 burnout predictor.

Stress Scenarios & Responses

Scenario 1: "Your E-ITS gap is concerning"

Response: "I understand that concern. Let me be clear about my approach: I don't implement standards I don't fully understand. My plan would be:

Phase 1 (Months 1-3): Partner with an experienced E-ITS consultant, conduct gap analysis, create implementation roadmap.

Phase 2 (Months 4-12): Work hands-on with consultant to implement, document everything, build internal knowledge.

Phase 3 (Year 2+): Take full ownership, maintain compliance, train team.

I've successfully implemented complex systems I wasn't initially expert in - Google Workspace migration in 2012, Entu platform - by following this learn-implement-own pattern. The key is being honest about what you don't know and bringing in the right expertise."

Scenario 2: "Why should we hire you when you left before?"

Response: "Fair question. In 2012, I had accomplished what I set out to do - built the infrastructure, migrated systems, established processes. At that point, I needed to grow in areas EKA couldn't provide - large-scale development, diverse technical challenges, team leadership at scale.

I've now done that. I've led development teams, built systems for 30+ organizations, worked across multiple technical stacks, and gained the breadth of experience needed to lead EKA's IT strategy for the next decade.

The difference between 2012 and now is maturity and capability. I'm ready to commit long-term to building something sustainable, not just implementing one-off projects."

Scenario 3: "We need someone who can start immediately with E-ITS"

Response: "If E-ITS implementation is the absolute top priority starting day one, then you should understand my learning curve. However, consider:

1. E-ITS implementation is typically a 12-18 month process - nobody truly 'starts immediately'
2. I can hire consultants and begin the process within the first month
3. My institutional knowledge means I won't waste time learning EKA's systems, politics, and processes
4. I'll be productive on other priorities (team leadership, strategy, operations) from day one

If you need someone who's implemented E-ITS five times before, I'm not that person. If you need someone who can successfully lead the implementation while also managing all other IT responsibilities, I'm highly qualified."

Scenario 4: "The budget is very limited"

Response: "I've operated in constrained budget environments my entire career - public sector, startups, nonprofits. In 2012, I reduced email costs by 90% while improving service. At PÖFF, we built a festival platform on minimal budget.

My approach:

- Prioritize ruthlessly (what actually moves the needle?)
- Leverage open source and cost-effective cloud services
- Build vs buy analysis (sometimes building is cheaper)
- Incremental improvement over big-bang projects
- Measure and demonstrate ROI

Limited budget isn't a dealbreaker - unclear priorities and lack of leadership support are. If we're aligned on goals, I can work within tight constraints."

30/60/90 Day Plan (If Asked)

First 30 Days: Listen & Learn

Goals:

- Understand current state
- Build relationships
- Identify urgent issues
- Quick wins

Activities:

- Meet with every IT team member individually
- Interview key stakeholders (faculty, admin, students)
- Audit current systems and infrastructure
- Review documentation (what exists)
- Assess E-ITS readiness
- Identify top 3 urgent issues
- Deliver 1-2 quick wins (e.g., fix long-standing annoyance)

Deliverable: 90-day roadmap based on findings

First 60 Days: Plan & Prioritize

Goals:

- Develop IT strategy
- Begin E-ITS process
- Address urgent issues
- Build team capability

Activities:

- Draft IT digital development strategy
- Engage E-ITS consultant, begin gap analysis
- Launch 1-2 priority projects
- Establish regular stakeholder communication
- Participate in first inter-university IT meeting
- Review vendor contracts and relationships
- Implement quick security improvements
- Begin team training/development

Deliverable: Approved IT strategy and budget proposal

First 90 Days: Execute & Stabilize

Goals:

- Demonstrate value
- Build momentum
- Establish credibility
- Set foundation for long-term

Activities:

- Complete E-ITS gap analysis and roadmap
- Deliver 2-3 visible improvements
- Establish regular IT service reporting
- Implement priority security measures
- Build documentation practices
- Create IT department goals for year
- Establish innovation pipeline
- Foster team cohesion

Deliverable: Quarterly report to leadership with metrics and progress

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Success Metrics (First Year)

Operational Excellence

- **System uptime:** 99.5%+ for critical systems
- **Support ticket resolution:** 90%+ within SLA
- **User satisfaction:** Measurable improvement in faculty/student surveys
- **Security incidents:** Zero major breaches, documented incident response process

Strategic Progress

- **E-ITS:** Gap analysis complete, implementation roadmap approved, Phase 1 underway
- **IT Strategy:** Documented, approved, resourced digital development strategy
- **Team:** Clear roles, development plans, improved morale (measured)
- **Budget:** Demonstrated ROI on key initiatives, secured resources for year 2

Stakeholder Value

- **Faculty:** At least 3 new tools/services supporting teaching/research
- **Students:** Improved digital experience (faster Wi-Fi, better labs, easier access)
- **Administration:** Better reporting, compliance progress, cost optimization
- **Partnerships:** Active participation in inter-university cooperation with tangible benefits

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Personal Mindset

Confidence Anchors

1. **I've done this job before at this institution - successfully.**
2. **I have 13 additional years of growth since then.**
3. **I'm a 100% match on required qualifications.**
4. **I genuinely care about EKA's mission.**
5. **I have nothing to prove and nothing to hide.**

Authenticity Principles

- Be honest about gaps (E-ITS)
- Don't oversell or make promises I can't keep
- Show genuine enthusiasm for the work
- Acknowledge challenges realistically
- Demonstrate problem-solving thinking, not just technical knowledge

Energy Management

- **Get good sleep the night before**
- **Eat a proper breakfast**
- **Arrive calm and centered**
- **Remember: they need someone good, I am good at this**
- **This is a conversation, not a test**

Final Checklist

Knowledge Preparation

- ☒ Understand current EKA context
- ☒ Identify key challenges and gaps
- ☒ Prepare responses to likely questions
- ☒ Develop strategy for first 90 days
- ☒ Research E-ITS requirements
- ☒ Compile relevant examples and stories

Materials Preparation

- ☐ Print CV and motivation letter
- ☐ Prepare portfolio/examples (if relevant)
- ☐ Write down key questions to ask
- ☐ Prepare notepad for taking notes

Logistics

- ☐ Confirm interview time and location
- ☐ Plan transportation (arrive early)
- ☐ Professional attire prepared
- ☐ Phone charged, backup contacts saved

Mental Preparation

- ☐ Review confidence anchors
- ☐ Visualize successful interview
- ☐ Practice key opening statement
- ☐ Get good rest the night before
- ☐ Morning routine to arrive energized

Closing Thoughts

This is not just another job interview - it's an opportunity to return to an institution you care about, in a role you've proven you can excel at, with significantly more experience and capability than before.

Your job in this interview is to:

1. **Show them who you are now** (not who you were in 2012)
2. **Demonstrate you understand the challenges** (E-ITS, digital strategy, team leadership)
3. **Prove you can deliver** (track record, specific examples, practical plans)
4. **Convey genuine commitment** (this isn't a stepping stone)

Remember:

- You're evaluating them as much as they're evaluating you
- Be yourself - authenticity wins
- Focus on value you bring, not gaps you have
- Show enthusiasm without desperation

You've got this. You're not trying to convince them you might be good - you're showing them you are good, with proof.

Good luck, and bring that calm confidence that comes from knowing you can actually do the job.

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